Dungeons & Gardens

The salt spray stings your faces as the longship grinds against the icy pier of Palebank Village. The groan of splintering ice mixes with the cries of gulls and the shouts of dockworkers bundled in furs. Palebank Villages greets you with a blast of frigid air, a stark contrast to the relative warmth of the southern seas you've left behind. The sky above is a perpetual grey, heavy with the promise of more snow.

You've endured weeks at sea, braving treacherous currents and icy squalls aboard the *Frostwind*, a sturdy, if somewhat cramped, longship captained by the weathered and taciturn Jarl Stonebeard. The journey itself proved more than just a test of sea legs; it was during those long, monotonous days and nights that your paths first crossed. Over shared meals of salted fish and hardtack, huddled around the meager warmth of the ship's brazier, you discovered a shared purpose beneath your disparate backgrounds. Perhaps it was a whispered conversation overheard in the galley, a chance encounter on deck under the pale moonlight, or a late-night debate in the cramped crew quarters, but you each realized you were drawn north by the same alluring whispers: the rediscovery of Aeorian ruins, remnants of a lost civilization swallowed by the Frostfell. Tales of lost cities and powerful artifacts have spread like wildfire, carried on the winds and traded in taverns from the Menagerie Coast to the shores of Wildemount. These stories have lured explorers, scholars, and fortune-seekers alike to this desolate land, and fate, or perhaps something more, has brought you together on this shared voyage.

Palebank Village, a ramshackle collection of wooden buildings huddled against the harsh landscape, serves as the primary gateway to the frozen Island of Eiselcross to the North. Here, amidst the bustle of fur traders, fisherfolk, grizzled explorers, shady mercenaries and hopeful fortune-seekers, you disembark. The air is thick with anticipation, a palpable sense of excitement mixed with a healthy dose of apprehension. The promise of uncovering lost knowledge, powerful magic, and perhaps even unimaginable wealth hangs heavy in the air, a beacon in this frozen wilderness. But the frozen shores of Eiselcross hold many secrets, and the ruins of Aeor are guarded by more than just ice and snow. Ancient dangers stir beneath the frozen surface, and the secrets you seek may come at a terrible price. Your journey into the heart of Eiselcross begins now, the moment your boots touch the frozen ground.

Welcome to Palebank Village

In the frosty expanse of the colder reaches of Wildemount, in the Greying Wildlands south of the Islands of Eiselcross, lies the haphazard cluster known as Palebank Village. It is a place more cobbled together than planned, with just over a hundred cabins and shacks pressed against the northern cliffs that rise a mere fifteen feet against the lapping rhythms of the icy harbor waves. The docks, busy with the absence of departing ships, whisper tales of neglect and wariness.

On this frigid day, the village is subdued, gathered in mournful procession for the unfortunate Urgon, a dwarven adventurer whose final journey is to the graveyard west of the harbor. There, encased in a casket more suitable for a relic than a beloved friend, he lies suspended in a state of frozen eternity. Villagers whisper tales of his return from a year-long venture into Eiselcross, burdened with treasures and a chilling affliction. Despite countless efforts, Urgon was never able to find warmth. Eventually, blue streaks marred his pallor, snaking through his veins, until his entire being succumbed to the grip of frost.

We follow the procession, taking note of the landscape dotted with quaint inns and supply shops. Amongst the mourners stands a weathered elf adorned with the insignia of a "Glassblade." Introducing himself as Elro, he shares that the usual voyages to Aeor have ceased, a silent testament to the mystery shrouding Urgon's demise. Elro seeks our help in unveiling the source of this insidious curse, admitting that Urgon's home remains unexplored.

Word reaches us quickly that another villager named Tulgi shows similar symptoms—her fate seemingly entwined with Urgon's. Fortuitously, their cabins stand in proximity.

Beer with the Locals

In the heart of the village, a jovial dwarf Arl Bortock tends bar at the local tavern. Elara, ever inquisitive, engages Arl in conversation about Urgon's recent exploits. A night's rest is negotiated—two rooms for eight silver pieces—before we are served beer by the bucket and a meal of squid rolls.

Bill, a stalwart Glassblade at one of the tavern tables, emphasizes that due to the danger of the curse, all boats are being warned off from Palebank's docks. Meanwhile, we learn Tulgi is a solitary trapper, her life a mystery to most.

The Cabins of Urgon and Tulgi

With this knowledge, we venture to Urgon's cabin where another Glass Blade vigilantly stands post. Halite leads us inside, where chaos has left its mark. The mounted head of a snowy beast with grey horns seems to oversee the search. Books are strewn about, gear tossed aside as if someone has desperately sought something. Scarlet's keen eyes catch sight of a grappling hook, swiftly claiming it. Meanwhile, with a sharp mind for details, Halite discovers a receipt within a book. Dated two months prior, it records the sale of Aeorian items at the local Pelc's Curiosities for a handsome sum of one thousand gold pieces. Among the items: a dagger, a scroll case, a jade statue, a quiver of arrows, a jasper-set silver ring, and two blue glass vials.

Our eyes trace tracks leading to Tulgi Lutan's snow-burdened cabin. The warmth of a fierce fire belies the untouched exterior and shuttered windows. Scarlet's knock brings a curt response, followed by Elara's soft words which coax the door open. Tulgi's face, marked by the same blue streaks that have doomed

Appendix D — Additional Rules

Cook's Utensils

Source: Xanathar's Guide to Everything

Adventuring is a hard life. With a cook along on the journey, your meals will be much better than the typical mix of hardtack and dried fruit.

Components. Cook's utensils include a metal pot, knives, forks, a stirring spoon, and a ladle.

History. Your knowledge of cooking techniques allows you to assess the social patterns involved in a culture's eating habits.

Medicine. When administering treatment, you can transform medicine that is bitter or sour into a pleasing concoction.

Survival. When foraging for food, you can make do with ingredients you scavenge that others would be unable to transform into nourishing meals.

Prepare Meals. As part of a short rest, you can prepare a tasty meal that helps your companions regain their strength. You and up to five creatures of your choice regain 1 extra hit point per Hit Die spent during a short rest, provided you have access to your cook's utensils and sufficient food.

Cook's Utensils

Activity	DC
Create a typical meal	10
Duplicate a meal	10
Spot poison or impurities in food	15
Create a gourmet meal	15

Spells

Primal Savagery

Source: Xanathar's Guide to Everything

Transmutation Cantrip

Casting Time: 1 Action

Range/Area: Self
Components: S
Duration: Instantaneous
Attack/Save: Melee
Damage/Effect: Acid

You channel primal magic to cause your teeth or fingernails to sharpen, ready to deliver a corrosive attack. Make a melee spell attack against one creature within 5 feet of you. On a hit, the target takes 1d10 acid damage. After you make the attack, your teeth or fingernails return to normal.

The spell's damage increases by 1d10 when you reach 5th level (2d10), 11th level (3d10), and 17th level (4d10).

Urgon, is a testament to her shared affliction. She admits her illness, confessing that she and her sister Hulil, newcomers from Shady Creek Run, are in league with a crime syndicate. They have been sent to pilfer Aeorian treasures. It is they who have ransacked Urgon's home, and Tulgi now surrenders a finely wrought dagger into Kragor's keeping.

She says that her sister Hulil holds the remainder of the treasures in Croaker Cave, though Tulgi has not seen her in weeks.

Onward

With our next destination clear, we hike to Pelc's Curiosities. We find the shop marked by a dragon-gilded "P," where the front door sags invitingly open, beckoning us into the next chapter of this unfolding tale.

Pelc's Curiosities

The party stands outside Pelc's Curiosities, the door slightly ajar. Suspecting intruders, Whisper closes her eyes while softly purring "Maior et Fortior". The air around her shimmers momentarily as she draws on her inner ki in concentration. She then peers into the doors and the windows of the building. Despite her efforts, she cannot make out very much, though she hears enough rustling to make her hairs bristle. It sounds as though there are several inside ransacking the place. Scarlet joins Whisper's investigation, attempting to divine whether the noises might simply be animals, yet she senses no wildlife inside.

Preparing for potential conflict, Kragor stands up straight and stretches out his arms as if to grasp a weapon. In a loud yet distant voice he exclaims "Malleum Evoco". Suddenly ethereal shadows stream in from all directions and coalesce into an obsidian black war hammer with an angular and brutal head. Its every surface is etched with subtle twisting runes. Kragor hefts the weapon with both hands, then widens his stance with feet planted firmly on the ground.

The goliath Halite likewise readies himself, his massive frame towering above even Kragor. With deliberate, practiced movements, he adjusts his gleaming bronze shield, its surface etched with intricate clan markings. In one enormous hand he carefully grips his trident, its three wickedly barbed prongs designed not just to pierce, but to tear and rend flesh. The trident promises not just death, but a savage, lingering demise.

Surprise

Inside Pelc's Curiosities lie the answers to the freezing curse. Anxious for action, Elara takes a deep breath, tapping into her well of magic. Her fingers trace the air, summoning the rhythm of a battle drum. Her magic ignites, sending an illusory racket echoing from within the shop's shadowed walls. Startled into silence, the adversaries within hold their breath, their schemes momentarily unraveled. As Whisper crouches beside her, he senses the tension mounting. Without warning, a crossbow bolt whistles past, narrowly missing him. Elara's calculated ruse works, urging their foes to react blindly. The door slams shut, a temporary barrier between them and danger.

"So much for the element of surprise," mutters Kragor.

Undeterred, Elara shoulders the door open again. Darkness seeped around her like ink in water, yet her keen eyes, accustomed to shadow, discerned the outlines of two startled bandits amid the cluttered ruins of the shop. Ancient relics lay strewn about like casualties of an invisible war; toppled bookshelves and shattered relics spoke of a hasty, chaotic search.

The bandits, their nerves frayed by Elara's eerie magic, released their crossbow bolts in a jittery frenzy. The bolts missed their marks, striking harmlessly against worn brick and aged wood. Assessing the chaotic tableau before her, Elara hesitated; caution whispered in her ear, suggesting a withdrawal from direct assault into strategic retreat.

Inspiration and Fog

She retreated to her waiting comrades, her mind spinning a fresh tapestry of strategy. Checking again her surroundings, Kragor meets her gaze with a blend of curiosity and gruff admiration. Her eyes locked with his, and in that silent exchange, understanding was born. Elara struck her hand drum, each beat a pulse of power transmitted through the air, wrapping around Kragor like a cloak of inspiration. The rhythmic symphony reignited his focus, sharpening his spirit for the clash ahead.

Appendix C — The Vanquished

1. **First Bandit** — *Kragor* crushed the elf's head with a single blow of his war hammer in the fog-clouded Pelc's Curiosities.
2. **Second Bandit** — *Halite* skewered the elf's jaw with an uppercut from his trident, after *Scarlet* had initially injured him with her acid-laden, elongated claws.
3. **Third Bandit** — *Kragor's* hex and Eldritch Blast left the elf on the brink of death. The bandit surrendered.
4. **Fourth Bandit** — In the shadow of *Halite's* imposing stature, the final elf surrendered.
5. **First Giant Ice Frog** — *Kragor's* hex and blast combo disintegrates this ice frog, which had previously retreated into the pool with severe wounds from *Doctor Pepe* and *Whisper*.
6. **Second Giant Ice Frog** — *Elara* destroyed the frog with a radiant mote of energy, after it was initially injured by *Halite's* trident.
7. **Fifth Bandit** — The elf was felled by *Halite's* javelin after it was wounded by *Whisper's* sling.
8. **Sixth Bandit** — Pulverized by *Kragor's* Eldritch Blast after *Elara's* starry wisp scorched the elf.
9. **Seventh Bandit** — *Halite* pierced the dwarf bandit with deadly precision, after which the dwarf surrendered and was bound.
10. **Acolyte** — Slaughtered by a bolt to the neck from *Doctor Pepe's* crossbow.
11. **Hulil Lutan** — *Halite's* javelin punctured the dwarf's heart, ending her after having been worn down by a first javelin, two bolts from *Doctor Pepe*, an arrow and Dissonant Whispers from *Elara*, *Kragor's* hex and Eldritch Blast, and *Scarlet's* shillelagh.

19. **Scarlet**: A druid attuned to nature's magic. She protects and guides her comrades using her connection to the natural world and magical arts, recently exploring greater communion with nature's forms.
20. **Tulgi Lutan**: A solitary trapper cursed with the same affliction as Urgon. She's entangled in the theft of Aeorian treasures amidst her ties to a Shadycreek Run syndicate.
21. **Urgon**: A dwarven adventurer whose return from Eiselcross with treasures and subsequent icy demise sparks the central mystery of the story.
22. **Verla Pelc**: The owner of Pelc's Curiosities, found frozen lifeless in her shop by the adventurers, indicating the curse's lethal reach.
23. **Westeroff**: A retired wizard living in Palebank Village, offering limited assistance to the adventurers, providing insight into some magical artifacts.
24. **Whisper**: A tabaxi with exceptional agility and stealth, she often takes on scouting roles, using her skills to navigate tense situations and inform party strategy, now with an enhanced ability to heal herself.

But as this is happening, Scarlet quickly reacts. "Voco Nubes!" she bellows while raising her gnarled staff to the sky. Her eyes close in concentration as she summons nature's veil. Wisps of mist curl around her fingers before surging toward the building. The vapor seeps through cracks and under doorways, expanding rapidly into a dense, swirling fog that blankets the room. The once-clear space becomes an opaque, ethereal haze, obscuring vision and muffling sound. The druid smiles, knowing the shrouded interior will confound any occupants, granting her allies the advantage they seek within the murky cover of the fog cloud. She wastes no time taking advantage of it herself: she sneaks into the building and hugs the wall, moving to the right. She can hear others moving inside as well, but can make out nothing through the fog.

First Blood

Watching one of his allies attacked and another diving into the fog and what must certainly be mortal danger, Kragor strains to think. He feels like a sitting duck outside with obscured enemies inside, ready to make a pincushion out of him with their crossbow bolts. Taking a deep breath to overcome his fear, he too rushes through the doorway into the shrouding fog, gripping his massive conjured war hammer tightly. Unable to see, he positions himself protectively before where he believes Scarlet to be, straining to detect any threats hidden in the mist. A sudden noise to his left spurs him into action. He swings wildly, the war hammer arcing through the air, and feels a heavy impact followed by a muffled crunch. The enemy's body collapses to the ground with a lifeless thud.

The Roof

Outside, Whisper's sharp tabaxi senses are attuned to every movement around her. As her gaze sweeps upward, it catches upon an unexpected anomaly: a crouched form perched on the rooftop. Though the figure's features are obscured by distance, their posture is a tapestry of uncertainty, a riddle waiting to be unraveled. Without hesitation, Whisper draws upon her innate agility, launching herself up the building's facade, her movements a dance of precision and power. Within moments, she alights upon the roof beside the puzzled figure. As she closes in, a momentary clumsiness intrudes upon her fluid motion; her limbs entangle with the figure in a grapple that is awkward but surprisingly effective. Despite the ungraceful tangle of arms and legs, her determination holds fast, securing her quarry beneath the vast blue sky. The figure, now clearly a rogue based on their dark attire and tools of the trade hanging from their belt, desperately attempts to free themselves from Whisper's grasp, to no effect.

Counterattack

Halite now grasps the perilous choice the party has made in their recklessness. With a fierce resolve etched in the hard lines of his goliath visage, he charges through the fog-choked doorway, instinctively veering left to secure the flank opposite Scarlet and Kragor. The mist clings to him, a shroud of uncertainty, yet he moves with the confidence of one accustomed to the unseen. A bandit lunges at him, the attack a mere whisper of danger that dissolves into emptiness. Seizing the opportunity, Halite's fingers tighten around his trident, that harbinger of despair. With an expert thrust, the weapon slices through the fog, hungry for blood. It strikes true, embedding itself deep within the bandit with a sickening resistance, as though the weapon savored its work. Halite has to struggle to wrench it free from the bandit with raw power, the action accompanied by a dreadful noise that the fog quickly absorbs.

While recovering his favored weapon, Halite hears the "whoosh" of a crossbow bolt. He flinches, but he is not the target. He hears Kragor cry out in desperate pain.

The bolt had struck Kragor just below the collarbone, close to his heart. Blood flows unchecked, staining his leather armor.

Seconds later, another bolt pierces Scarlet and a sharp pain flares beneath her ribs. Blood seeps into her cloak, mingling with the forest's earthy scent.

Rogue Fall

Whisper, poised at the edge of the rooftop's precipice, maintains a firm hold on the rogue. Despite the rogue's cunning and agility, he struggles to free an arm to launch a counterattack with his dagger. Nevertheless, Whisper's sharp claws and expert grip keep him securely restrained. Beneath her, the store's chaos swirls, a symphony of survival and sorcery; each cry, each clash a note struck sharp in the chord of battle below. Her decision solidifies with the clarity of ice forming, abandoning subtlety for swiftness. With a sudden, fluid ferocity, she thrusts the entangled rogue from the roof, the figure plummeting and landing with a sickening thud upon the hard earth. The world contracts around her as she vaults down, feline grace reclaiming momentum in mid-air, her heart a steady drumbeat beneath her silken fur. She lands silently, flowing through the doorway like a stream of midnight water into the tempest of friend and foe, ready once more to thread her prowess into the weaving of combat's fierce tapestry. The thrown rogue, battered and broken, lies forgotten amidst the rubble.

Elara is startled by Whisper's sudden reappearance. Despite this, she remains focused on the building, her senses registering enough to grasp that her companions are in grave danger. She urgently calls out to Scarlet, telling her to dispel the fog cloud, which Scarlet promptly does. Without hesitation, Elara rushes to join her and Kragor inside. Whisper follows but pauses in the doorway, alert for threats inside or out.

Medic!

Surveying Scarlet and Kragor's injuries, she quickly assesses that Kragor's condition is more critical. She places her hands gently on the grievous puncture wound left by the crossbow bolt, her touch glowing with divine energy. The healing light rapidly closes the wound, restoring vitality to his mottled green-gray skin. Kragor, caught off guard yet deeply appreciative, meets Elara's kind gaze, and a silent bond is forged between the orc and the aasimar.

Final Blows

As Elara is tending to Kragor, Scarlet runs towards a nearby bandit that is just now orienting themselves after the fog dispersed. Eyes glowing with untamed magic, Scarlet calls upon nature's wrath. With a fierce, primal incantation, her fingertips elongate into razor-sharp claws, dripping with corrosive acid. In a swift motion, she lashes out, and her savage strike lands true. The bandit staggers back, pain etched across their face as the toxic claws rend through leather and flesh, leaving a searing wound. The druid's usually gentle demeanor is momentarily overshadowed by raw, feral power, as the bandit teeters on the brink of defeat, humbled by nature's unforgiving might.

Halite steps forward with a grim determination, his massive form casting a foreboding shadow over the bandit struggling to stay upright from Scarlet's fierce attack. With a swift and fluid motion defying his immense size, Halite shifts his weight back, then lunges forward with an uppercut trajectory. It pierces through the air with a whistling sound, meeting the bandit's chest in a visceral collision. The force of the jab lifts the bandit off his feet momentarily, his final gasp cut short by the weapon's deadly embrace. Life flickers out of his eyes, and the limp body slides down the trident's length. Halite grimaces, more out of reflex than malice, as he shakes the bandit free with a swift, practiced motion, the lifeless form dropping to the ground with a thud.

Now sufficiently recovered to rejoin the battle, Kragor focuses his attention on the bandit far across the room that he suspects of shooting him. Although he can't be sure of the bandit's guilt, he raises his war hammer toward his

Appendix B — Dramatis Personae

1. **Adventurers**: The primary group consisting of Elara, Halite, Kragor, Scarlet, Whisper, and Doctor Pepe. Brought together by the shared quest to unravel the mystery of a curse tied to Aeorian artifacts.
2. **Arl Bortock**: A jovial dwarf who tends bar in the local tavern and interacts with the adventurers, providing them with refreshments and useful local insights.
3. **Bandits (Croaker Cave)**: Another group working under Hulil, tasked with defending the cave. They confront the adventurers as they delve deeper into the cave's secrets.
4. **Bandits (Pelc's Curiosities)**: Followers of Hulil, breaking into Pelc's Curiosities searching for clues about the curse. They engage with the adventurers in combat but surrender after defeat.
5. **Bill**: A Glassblade, providing warnings at the tavern about the dangers associated with the curse impacting Urgon and Tulgi.
6. **Doctor Pepe**: Originally a rogue observing the adventurers stealthily, he reveals his true intent and aligns with them, contributing with his investigative prowess.
7. **Elara**: An aasimar bard whose musical talents and spellcasting abilities support and enhance the party's efforts in healing and strategic planning.
8. **Elro**: A Glassblade leader who introduces the adventurers to the cursed mysteries of Palebank Village, enlisting their help to find the root cause.
9. **Fenton Tethwick**: Irven Liel's husband, part of the Liel-Tethwicks family traveling with Irven, ensuring the well-being of their twin tiefling daughters amidst the dangers of their journey.
10. **Gramini**: An elderly elf woman trading potions at the village docks, her wares and tales offer resources and clues to the adventurers.
11. **Halite**: The goliath fighter wielding a mighty trident, known for his strength and tactical astuteness during encounters. He has a newfound interest in cooking.
12. **Hulil Lutan**: The defeated dwarf priestess of Tiamat involved in the curse's mystery. She commanded operations and held stolen artifacts at Croaker Cave, seeking a cure for her ailment.
13. **Ingrid**: A chef aboard the *Remorhaz* with a deep connection to the moon, marked by lycanthropy, she unexpectedly teaches the adventurers cooking secrets that bridge magic and gastronomy.
14. **Irven Liel**: A bookseller traveling with his family, entwined in the tale due to his purchase of a blue powder vial, the catalyst for the ongoing curse mystery.
15. **Jarl Stonebeard**: The seasoned captain of the *Frostwind* and the *Remorhaz*, who ferries the adventurers through dangerous seas to Palebank Village and on to Syrinlya, maintaining a professional yet relaxed demeanor with an eye for managing both his ship and crew.
16. **Kragor**: An orc warlock, casting dark magic to strategically aid his allies and subdue enemies using curses and powerful eldritch blasts, now further empowered by new arcane discoveries.
17. **The Liel-Tethwicks**: A traveling family known in the story for their association with a blue powder vial. Includes Irven Liel, Fenton Tethwick (Irven's husband), and their twin tiefling daughters.
18. **Old Croaker**: A massive ice frog inhabiting Croaker Cave, it aids the adventurers across a subterranean pool, motivated by treats provided by the bandits and the adventurers.

storm giant in mid-roar, with intricate details capturing the raw power and majesty of its kind. The deep green jade shimmers with veins of gold, suggesting latent magical energies, and when held during a lightning storm, the statuette seems to vibrate softly, as if resonating with the storm's fury. Ancient runes inscribed at the base suggest it could be used in rituals to commune with primal forces of nature, potentially granting temporary insight or power related to storms.

Silver Ring

Jewelry

A silver ring with an inset jasper stone.

Hulil's Journal

Book, common

Hulil Lutan's journal, mentioning that she sold a vial of blue powder to Irven Liel.

target and shouts, "Te Exsecro!" The air shimmers with malevolent energy as a cold, dark aura coils around the bandit like an invisible serpent. Without hesitation, Kragor follows with another spell, yelling "Dolor," and unleashes a surge of eldritch energy from his war hammer that strikes the bandit square in the chest. The impact of the blast results in an ugly wound. Immediately, shadowy tendrils twist and curl over the shredded flesh causing it to blacken and crumble, leaving the bandit teetering on the brink of death.

Surrender

Halite, his towering form casting an imposing shadow across the cluttered interior of the ransacked antique shop, moved with purpose toward Kragor's target: a bandit whose bravado had been seared away by the crackling energy of the orc warlock's magic. The air still shimmered with the fading traces of arcane power, and the bandit, already on the brink of collapse, could only watch as the goliath fighter closed the distance between them like an inexorable force of nature.

The trident in Halite's grip gleamed with an unsettling menace, its barbed points promising a swift and painful end should it be called upon to deliver one. The bandit, a mere lithe elf in the presence of such formidable warriors, felt the weight of his own mortality for what seemed like the first time. His sword clattered to the wooden floor, a hollow sound that resonated through the shop, punctuating his surrender.

"I yield," the bandit croaked, his voice strained with fear and desperation. He raised his hands, palms open and empty, a universal sign of capitulation. His eyes darted to his remaining comrade, wide with silent urging.

The last standing bandit, who had watched the battle unfold with growing dread, knew the odds all too well. He had witnessed the fate of their fallen companions—three already dispatched with ruthless efficiency by the duo of Kragor and Halite. The decision was not a difficult one.

He dropped his own weapon, a well-worn crossbow, to the floor and raised his hands above his head in submission. "We don't want anymore trouble," he said, his voice carrying a tremor that matched the frantic beating of his heart.

Kragor surveyed the scene, his eyes, glowing faintly with residual magical energy, meeting Halite's. An unspoken understanding passed between them—this victory, as hard-fought as it was, did not need to claim further lives.

With the tension of combat beginning to ebb, the antique shop's air felt still, though the echoes of the skirmish lingered. Surrounded by overturned furniture and scattered relics of a bygone era, the bandits' surrender marked the end of the struggle, their lives spared by the mercy of those far mightier than they.

Whisper, having ensured the rogue she tossed from the roof was no longer a threat, finally entered the antique shop and closed the door behind her. As she did, the rogue moved to a crouched position around the corner, relieved that his theatrics had been successful. Intending to enter the building when the coast was truly clear, he remained vigilant, pressing his ear to the cool glass of the window to eavesdrop on the victorious adventurers.

Interrogation

Elara and Scarlet eyed the bandits with intensity, their curiosity piqued by the confession of surrender. "Who are you and what were you doing here?" Elara demanded, her voice steady yet demanding answers.

The first bandit, regaining a bit of composure but still visibly shaken, replied, "We were sent by Hulil, a priestess of Tiamat. She instructed us to search this place. Two months ago, there was a robbery here, and now Hulil's got this strange freezing sickness. She hoped we might find a clue here in the shop. But we found nothing."

Scarlet's gaze remained firm as she pressed

further, “Then why did you attack us?”

A hint of embarrassment colored the bandit’s cheeks. “We were spooked. We heard some weird noise, then you guys barged in. Especially that chick with a horn on her head,” he gestured toward Elara. “We panicked. We’re not used to dealing with people like you.”

In the meantime, the rogue outside, crouching below the window, absorbed the exchange, piecing together the dynamics at play.

Scarlet produced a weathered receipt with notations about Aeorian artifacts and presented it to the bandits. “Have you seen these items?”

“They’re with Hulil,” the bandit admitted reluctantly, his eyes on the documentation with evident recognition. “She’s at Croaker’s Cave,” confirming what the party had already learned from Hulil’s sister, Tulgi.

Satisfied with the information, Kragor dismissed the subdued bandits in no uncertain terms: “Leave everything and get out.” Seizing their chance, the bandits quickly discarded their weapons and coins before hurrying for the door, the rogue outside remaining concealed until the coast was truly clear.

Loot

After searching the bandits’ leavings and their late compatriots’ bodies, the party tallied the loot: 14 gold pieces, eight silver pieces, five crossbows, 30 bolts, five scimitars, and a dwarf-sized shirt blazoned with “Scanlan Shorthalt — The Meat Man Cometh”. (Elara judged this last item to be a rare find and might fetch as much as two gold pieces.)

The party then turned to the antique shop, assessing the chaos that engulfed it. The room was in disarray, bookshelves overturned and trinkets strewn about. Amidst the disorder, they stumbled upon a chilling sight—a frozen elf lying lifeless in bed. It was Verla Pelc, and the grim discovery confirmed that the place had not seen tidiness for weeks.

In a thorough inspection of both the shop and the dead bandits’ belongings, they discovered two bows and various odds and ends. Deciding a respite was in order, they planned to rest before heading to Croaker Cave.

Who is this guy?

Unbeknownst to the adventurers, the rogue remained vigilant, listening to their intentions and preparing to bide his time until they left.

Appendix A — Party Inventory

Purses

Who	GP	EP	SP	CP
Doctor Pepe	147	3	50	72
Elara	141	3	51	72
Halite	304	3	26	72
Kragor	119	3	41	72
Scarlet	148	3	41	72
Whisper	145	3	47	76

Inventory Adjustments

Who	What
Doctor Pepe	Scimitar
Doctor Pepe	Olive drab deerstalker
Doctor Pepe	130 crossbow bolts
Doctor Pepe	Æorian Dagger, +1
Doctor Pepe	Cook’s utensils
Elara	100 arrows
Elara	30 Arrows, +1
Halite	3 javelins
Halite	Crystal arcane focus item
Halite	Journal of Hulil Lutan
Halite	Cooking utensils
Kragor	Brass oil lamp (1sp)
Kragor	Cooking utensils
Whisper	Quarterstaff
Scarlet	Scimitar
Scarlet	Grappling hook

Equipment

Count	Item
1	Bottle of Bald Dwarf
1	Gilded Scroll Case
1	Jade Statuette of a Storm Giant
1	Silver Ring (50gp)
2	Potions of Healing
1	month of provisions

Arrows, +1

Weapon, uncommon

You have a +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls made with this piece of magic ammunition. Once it hits a target, the ammunition is no longer magical.

Aeorian Dagger, +1

Weapon, uncommon

A finely wrought dagger previously sold to Pelc’s Curiosities, pilfered by Tulgi Lutan, and surrendered by same to Kragor Grimstride. With the rest of the party’s blessing, Kragor ultimately gifted the dagger to Doctor Pepe.

You have a +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls made with this magic weapon.

This weapon has the following mastery property. To use this property, you must have a feature that lets you use it.

Nick. When you make the extra attack of the **Light** property, you can make it as part of the Attack action instead of as a Bonus Action. You can make this extra attack only once per turn.

Bald Dwarf Whisky

Consumable, uncommon

An Uthodurnian specialty spirit, with an estimated value of 25 gp.

Gilded Scroll Case

Gear

A finely crafted mahogany container adorned with gold filigree and inlaid gemstones, providing both beauty and protection for the scrolls inside. It features runes that offer magical safeguarding against damage, making it ideal for keeping valuable parchments secure.

Jade Statuette of a Storm Giant

Miscellaneous

A meticulously carved figurine, standing approximately eight inches tall, depicting a

few strings of her harp and chants "Vobiscum natura loquor". Her voice then rings soft yet authoritative, seeking connection. "Calm, my friend, we mean you no harm. How can we help you?" But the wolf regards her with unwavering silence— this creature is not born of mere wild instinct. Tension thrums through the air as it seems moments away from lunging.

Scarlet withdraws a yew leaf from her pouch. She presses it to her forehead, eyes closing as if to draw insight from ages past. Her arm extends gracefully, and in a swift flick of her wrist, she casts the energy outward. Her voice resonates through the cabin: "Oculi Naturae, aperite ad veritatem; quod latent, patefaciat." A subtle gleam envelops her, the spell woven, as she opens her senses to all signs of poison and disease. She finds a darker truth beneath fur and fang: lycanthropy dances along the wolf's essence, a curse as old as time.

The commotion draws more of the crew, Captain Stonebeard included. "What the hey??" he exclaims.

Understanding dawns as suspicion edges Scarlet's voice: "I think… that… That's Chef Ingrid!"

Whisper, earlier roused by the clamor, stealthily emerges, taking stock of the escalating scene. She moves with feline grace, fluidly dodging her companions to retrieve the amulet. She pivots, holding out the amulet and asking Haldor with uncertainty, "This should be with Ingrid, shouldn't it?"

Haldor glances at the amulet, confusion clouding his features. "Ingrid holds that dearer than anything," he says, clearly puzzled. "She'd never be without it willingly."

Whisper attempts to withdraw and take the amulet to safety, but the startled wolf lunges, its jaws closing around her arm with a merciless bite. Agony explodes through her senses, and she collapses to the floorboards, desperately clawing for traction to right herself.

In the chaos, Halite takes swift action. With practiced precision, he hurls his net, ensnaring the wild beast in a tangle of coarse fibers.

Kragor sprints forward, snatching the gleaming amulet from Whisper's trembling grasp. Intent on his objective, he attempts to fasten it around the wolf's neck, yet the snaring net hinders his movements. Even as he wrestles with the tangled mess, the wolf thrashes free, its eyes ablaze with the primal instinct to flee. It stands cornered, frantic and dangerous.

Amidst the tumult, Elara approaches with an uncanny tranquility. With a deft and unwavering hand, she settles the amulet upon the wolf's neck. As its fangs snap perilously close to her, an ancient magic unfurls; the transformation is violent and beautiful. Muscles ripple and contort beneath the sleek fur, bones audibly crack and reform with a sickening yet mesmerizing fluidity. The lupine snout retracts painfully back into a familiar dwarven face, eyes flicker from feral to intelligent with startling clarity. The wolf's savage growls fade into anguished cries as claws withdraw into slender fingers. In mere moments, the fearsome beast dissolves to reveal Ingrid, collapsed and vulnerable, her form shivering under the strain of the metamorphosis.

Silence reins as Ingrid stands, sheepish and shivering, caught between fear and relief. Elara, compassion in her heart, drapes a blanket over the chef's shoulders. Captain Stonebeard, with weary authority and a tone brooking no argument, commands, "Everyone back to bed! Nothing to see here!"

As the adventurers retreat upstairs, faintly echoing behind them is the Captain's low voice, tinged with inevitable frustration, "Well why the hells didn't you tell me before??"

Secrets of Croaker Cave

The party retraces their steps to the *Jolly Dwarf*, where warmth greets them like an old friend. As the tavern's door swings open, hearth light flickers along the walls, merging with murmurs and the clinking of mugs. After a day of skirmishes, they retire to modest rooms, voices still echoing with plans.

Morning in Palebank Village dawns with a crisp, biting air. Frost clings to windows, and the adventurers rise at half-past seven. Below, a kettle hisses, and the aroma of breakfast fills the inn. Unusually quiet due to the port's closure, the inn hosts only one other group— a family, a weary pair of men with twin tiefling girls. And even they soon depart, the door framing their retreat in the morning light.

Arl, the innkeeper, greets them cheerily. "Elro was around last night, looking for you lot," he says, "He'll be back soon for news."

As Halite asks about Croaker Cave, Arl's expression shifts subtly to one of caution. "Croaker Cave, you say? They call it that for good reason— the croaks of giant ice frogs echo from there, a sound that'd chill your bones if the cold hadn't already. None of the village folk dare set foot inside. They know where to find it, sure, but it's an unspoken rule here: no one goes into that cave."

Taking a seat, the party enjoys breakfast— warm bread, stew, and fish; a bargain at only five silver pieces— while Kragor inquires about Hulil, Tulgi's sister. Arl scratches his beard thoughtfully, his eyes narrowing as he sifts through what bits of information he possesses. "Ah, Tulgi," he begins slowly, weighing his words. "Can't say I knew she has a sister. These folks from Shadycreek Run— always a tangled web with them. Their kin aren't exactly welcome in Palebank. Suspicion tends to follow their kind."

Ever the pragmatic, Kragor poses another question: "What about healing potions? Do you know where we might procure some?"

Arl advises, "Try the docks. There's an old elf woman, Gramini, she sells them. Pricey, but worth it."

As breakfast concludes, Elro joins them, concern in his eyes. Scarlet updates him on their findings: connections between Tulgi, Hulil, and the village's affliction, and the tragic fate of Verla from Pelc's Curiosities. Elro nods, confirming suspicions about the Shadycreek Run families. News of dispatched bandits lightens his demeanor. "Less to worry about," he says, intending to send his men over to the shop to clean up.

Still curious about their next venture, Whisper inquires, "What makes Croaker Cave particularly dangerous?" Elro turns towards her, his gaze steady. "It's the giant ice frogs. Those are the reason folks steer clear."

Scarlet, drawing from her vast trove of natural knowledge, leans forward. "How large are these frogs?" she asks.

"About the size of a large wolf," Elro replies, conjuring a vivid image in their minds.

Scarlet nods, familiar with their temperate climate counterparts. She addresses the party. "I recall they aren't venomous, but they can certainly swallow a person whole. Their stomach acid dissolves their prey, and while they're smarter than regular frogs, they're not what you would call cunning. I knew a teacher once who kept one as a pet."

Before departing, Elro implores, "Root out those Shadycreek folks. The village would owe you greatly."

The party, girded by Elro's trust and responsibility, reflects on the tapestry they are unraveling— a tapestry that now leads them to the hidden depths of Croaker Cave and the shadows lurking within.

Adventuring is hard, let's go shopping

Braving the biting cold, our adventurers reach the docks— a sprawling network of paths and shanties, each whispering tales of a bygone era. They navigate these lanes, finding the shack they seek: a dilapidated structure with an askew "Goods for Sale" sign dangling overhead.

Elara steps forward as the negotiator. Halite opens the door, releasing the tinny clang of a bell. Inside, flickering firelight reveals shelves groaning under the weight of indescribable trinkets. Behind the counter emerges a wizened elf whose blue scarf and loose coat defy the chill that seeps through the shack's walls. Her eyes, sharp despite her age, study the newcomers with cautious curiosity.

"Well, well, what's this? Adventurers, by the look of you." Her voice, both raspy and warm, mirrors the fire's flicker. "What brings you here? Looking for trinkets, or is it something more substantial?"

Elara approaches, broaching the need for potions. "You must be Gramini. We seek anything to combat the freezing illness cursing this village."

The woman's expression shifts, a glint of sympathy mixing with practicality. "Ah, if you mean Urgon's ailment, that mystery is beyond my humble potions. But I have supplies for those brave enough to venture to Eiselcross. Dangerous place, that is."

She presents four health potions. "Usually 60 gold apiece, but business has been slow lately. I'll sell them for 50 each."

Seeing an opening, Elara leans in. "Could you let them go for 30 each? The road ahead is perilous."

Gramini chuckles, a sound steeped in kindness and shrewdness. "Below cost, Sweetie? But you've got charm, I'll give you that. Alright, 48 each. A gesture of goodwill."

The negotiation leaves Elara hopeful. With business nearing conclusion, curiosity tickles her again. "Heard any tales or warnings of late, Gramini?"

Leaning back, the old elf sighs. "Troubling times, indeed. The port's closed— no ships. Palebank seems to hold its breath, waiting for a storm to pass." Her voice drops to a whisper, eyes locking with Elara's. "That freezing disease, eating at the core. Aeor is where its dark magic likely thrives. Everything from that land carries a cost, mark my words."

Elara then suggests, "We're short on coin… Perhaps a barter?"

Kragor, catching on, brandishes a shirt emblazoned with the name Scanlan Shorthalt. Gramini's eyes gleam with recognition. "Him! I've seen him perform." Fond remembrance softens her demeanor.

She proposes, "I'll give you 15 gold off the potions for that."

Donning the bard's shirt with delight, Gramini is transformed into a giddy teenager for a few moments. "Scanlan was so charming!" Her laughter chimes like a song, sealing the deal.

As the party exits, spirits buoyed, Gramini's unexpected joy lingers, a beacon against the looming shadows.

Doctor Pepe

As the party approaches Croaker Cave, they note smoke spiraling upward from a natural chimney, etching the sky with its ashen tendrils. Despite the spectral warning, the front opening of the cave appears unguarded.

Unbeknownst to them, the rogue that Whisper had previously encountered lies in wait, having shadowed the party from Palebank. As they draw nearer, he steps free of the forest's embrace, his presence a sudden ripple in the serene tableau.

"Hail, Friends! I mean you no harm," he calls

moon, nothing more."

Kragor nodded slowly, satisfied with the simple explanation. "Ah, nice. Moon is… nice."

Ingrid chuckles softly, her eyes momentarily distant as if recalling secrets long kept. But with Kragor content and unlikely to probe further, the moment passes.

The Crick Queen's Call

After the splendid meal, the crew gathers on the main deck, their camaraderie warming the cool sea air. The formal atmosphere dissolves into laughter, drifting alongside seabirds' cries. Captain Stonebeard, usually stoic, joins them, a rare smile on his lips.

Mera, the navigator, clears a space among the tarps and rigging, revealing a makeshift table from wooden crates. "Shall we play 'The Crick Queen's Call'?" she proposes, her tone promising intrigue.

Whisper, perched aloft in the rigging, casts a disinterested glance, her paws busy with knots.

Players gather, each contributing a silver piece to the pot. Mera's eyes gleam with competitive fire as she begins the opening move. Kragor grins, tusks gleaming as he raises the stakes, challenging with a clink of silver.

Elara, Doctor Pepe, and Halite accept the challenge, sliding their tokens forward. The game is a tapestry of glances, strategies, and the jangle of coins.

Scarlet leans back, watching the tides of fortune. "Some hands aren't worth playing," she says, folding.

Elara, graceful as in her musical performances, reveals "The Even Hand," drawing groans and applause. "I hope you're not always this lucky," Kragor grumbles, amused.

Coins shift toward Elara, but Doctor Pepe grins, eyes gleaming. "Time for a rematch," he challenges. Another round, with spirits undeterred.

This time, Doctor Pepe's luck turns, his hand a bounty of surprise. Applause follows his victory.

"Kept a few tricks hidden, rogue?" Elara teases, recognizing shared cunning.

As night deepens, the game winds down, and players and crew retreat to their bunks, content with the day's camaraderie.

Shapes shift in the night

In the heart of night, Halite and Kragor awaken to a cacophony of crashing and banging, immediately vigilant as they identify the disturbance as emanating from the kitchen. Within moments, they nudge Elara and Scarlet into wakefulness.

Alert and battle-ready, Halite takes point, leading the quartet down the narrow, creaking passageway to the kitchen. There, as the lamplight spills through the doorway, they behold First Mate Ironfist and Haldor, both wide-eyed and tense with faces set like stone, confronting an icy-furred adversary— a fearsome winter wolf with eyes burning frost-blue.

Kragor's gaze darts about, landing on Ingrid's amulet, discarded and glinting forlornly on the floor beside one of the bunks. His brows furrow in recognition and curiosity. Without hesitation, he whispers a few arcane words, summoning a protective embrace of magical frost that envelops him, shimmering with power.

Next, Kragor conjures a spectral, floating hand and sends it rushing past the wolf in an attempt to use the ethereal appendage as a distraction. The wolf, however, remains undeterred, its focus shifting toward Ironfist with almost predatory tunnel vision, yet restraint holds its posture for the moment.

Sensing a chance for diplomacy, Elara plucks a

says longingly. “I must learn of these waters.” He shows Whisper how to tackle stubborn ice frozen into the ropes, his fingers deft from life in icy lands.

Kragor steps onto the deck, shivering but focused, and casts his net into the sea. As he hauls it back, he’s caught by surprise— not just fish but a barnacle-crusted brass oil lamp lands in his hand. “There’s something to polish,” he murmurs, weighing it in his palm, assessing the worth— a silver’s gain, perhaps.

Elara joins the hunt as well, casting her net into the swirling depths. But it is met with cruel resistance, and the fibers rend and tear. Undeterred, Elara rallies a few seasoned crew hands to help her mend and weave the net whole once more.

Halite’s and Scarlet’s efforts pay off as their nets bring up a writhing mass of fish, including an iridescent marlin, tuna, and musk flounder, making quite an impression with the crew.

With the day’s catch secured, the adventurers gather in the ship’s warm galley. Chef Ingrid, eyes bright with pride, welcomes them with a smile.

“Gather ’round, friends! The sea has blessed us, and I invite you to craft a feast worthy of our journey,” she announces, gesturing to the array of fresh fish. “I’ll share the secrets of a meal so fine, even the gods would envy us.”

The galley buzzes as the adventurers gather around Ingrid, each busy with chopping and seasoning under her watchful eye. Three particularly adept students catch her attention: Kragor, Halite, and Doctor Pepe.

Kragor, with surprising delicacy, carefully fillets a fish. “Didn’t know I’d be good at anything more than swinging a war hammer,” he mused.

Ingrid nods, adjusting his grip. “Precision is key, Kragor, whether in the kitchen or on the battlefield.”

Halite, assessing spices for his rub, observes, “It’s like a strategic battle plan. Each seasoning has its purpose.”

“Well said, Halite,” Ingrid replies, admiring his work. “Strategy is both simple and bold, in combat and flavor.”

Nearby, Doctor Pepe peels vegetables with the finesse of a master thief. “Cooking is like planning a perfect heist,” he jokes. “But the treasure’s tastier.”

Ingrid chuckles. “You’ve certainly stolen the show, Doctor Pepe.”

As the meal’s aroma fills the galley, Ingrid gathers them around the table. “Feast your eyes and senses,” she declars. “This is more than food— it’s the fruit of your labor.”

Each adventurer basks in a warm glow of satisfaction. Their hearts are as full as their bellies; the bonds between them strengthen with shared laughter and the subtle symphony of clinking plates. Chef Ingrid, her eyes twinkling with a mixture of pride and mischief, approaches Kragor, Halite, and Doctor Pepe. With a flourish as grand as any mage’s spell, she unfurls a satchel of gleaming cooking utensils before them.

“Behold,” she declares, her voice a melodic lilt that dances on the evening breeze, “for you have not merely consumed a feast of meals, but of knowledge. You have stirred the cauldron of curiosity, seasoned your souls, and now, you too are alchemists of flavor. May these tools guide your hands as you concoct dishes that rival the nectar of the gods themselves.”

As he admires their handiwork and their instructor, Kragor’s curiosity is piqued by the amulet dangling from Chef Ingrid’s neck. It is a grand silver talisman of a crescent moon alongside an array of arcane runes. His deep voice gruff yet oddly gentle, he asks “Chef Ingrid, what is that shiny thing around your neck? Looks… important.”

Ingrid replies, her gaze distant, anchored yet free. “Ah, a trifle,” she murmurs, the moon’s silver glow reflected softly within her eyes. “It is a simple reminder of my connection to the

out, raising his hands in a gesture of peace. “I have something I believe you need to know.”

Scarlet and Whisper exchange glances before fixing their gazes upon the rogue. Recognition flickers in Whisper’s eyes, a soft chuckle escaping her lips as she recalls their prior exchange on the rooftops of Pelc’s Curiosities. Scarlet’s expression is more guarded as she steps forward, her tone firm yet open. “Who are you?” she demands, her eyes narrowing with a blend of caution and curiosity. “And what do you want?”

The rogue spreads his arms in a gesture of openness. “Let me introduce myself. I am called Doctor Pepe,” he announces. “I assure you, I was not a party to the bandits you encountered before. Like you, I’ve been drawn into the orbit of this mystery, investigating the source of this debilitating disease afflicting the village.”

Kragor steps forward, his bearing equal parts caution and curiosity. “Well met, Doctor Pepe. What do you know of this cave?”

“Just before daybreak, I witnessed three cloaked figures enter the cave— a dwarf and two elves, if I’m not mistaken.” Doctor Pepe’s eyes, sharp and perceptive, scan the adventurers’ faces, gauging their reaction. “Whatever transpires within, it may well relate to the affliction that has beset Palebank.”

The party exchanges thoughtful glances. After weighing their options, the adventurers come to a shared conclusion. Offering the rogue a nod of acceptance, Kragor extends the group’s unspoken consensus. “Then let us consider you an ally, Doctor Pepe. Together, we may better contend with whatever lies within the heart of Croaker Cave.”

Trepidation’s threshold

As the party assesses the scene at the cave entrance, Elara’s sharp eyes catch sight of myriad footprints— heavy and light, large and small— tracing paths both in and out of the cavern’s yawning mouth.

Gathering in a tight circle, they weigh their options and decide on a reconnaissance mission. It is swiftly determined that Doctor Pepe, with his keen investigative insights, and Whisper, with her silent grace, will venture in to scout the darkness and report back to the group.

To aid them in the shadowy depths, Elara steps forward and gently strums her harp, weaving magic through its strings. She sings, “Sol invictus,” and with her melody, a spare dagger that Doctor Pepe holds aloft begins to glow. The light emanating from the blade now serves as both a beacon and a ward against the shadows lurking within the cave.

As Doctor Pepe and Whisper step cautiously into the cave, the world narrows around them to the soft glow of magical light. The air grows cooler, the dampness clinging to their skin like an insistent whisper. About ten feet in, they encounter a pool of water, its murky depths disturbed only by the occasional ripple from droplets falling from above.

Whisper, pausing to scan the area, notes that the ceiling, though ten feet high, bristles with stalactites, reducing the navigable space to eight feet. The constant drip of water echoes in the chamber, joined intermittently by the deep croaks of unseen amphibians. These sounds seem to resonate with the very bones of the cave, sending a shiver across her fur.

Doctor Pepe, moving with deliberate quiet, approaches the pool’s edge to gain a better vantage. He squints across the still water, and on the far side, he discerns the tip of a wooden beam jutting slightly from the shadows. Suddenly he recalls that the three figures he saw entering the cave earlier were carrying a beam: this must be the way across.

Ambush

Whisper’s usual grace falters when she hits a jagged stalagmite, unleashing a sharp hiss that pierces the cave’s silence. Instantly, the murky

pool erupts, and two mastiff-sized blue frogs emerge, their slick bodies glinting ominously.

One frog leaps at Doctor Pepe, its jaw snapping with ferocious hunger. His reflexes, sharp from experience, save him; he sidesteps as its maw closes on empty air. But the second frog's attention locks onto Whisper. With a sudden lurch, it fastens its jaws around her, seriously wounding her. Its coarse tongue feels rough against her fur as it pins her with a vice-like grip. Whisper's world constricts around the raw strength of the creature, her body momentarily immobilized by the force of its bite.

Her once luxurious fur matted with blood and frost, her breath shallow and labored, Whisper summons her inner strength to claw free, leaving shallow crimson trails across the frog's blue skin in retaliation.

Outside, Elara leads the party at the cave entrance. "They're in trouble," she asserts, urgency lacing her voice. "We need to move!"

Within, the rhythmic echo of boots suggests more danger is approaching, but out of necessity, Doctor Pepe and Whisper remain focused on the immediate threat. Doctor Pepe turns his attention to the wounded frog threatening Whisper. His shortsword pierces its slick flesh, and his dagger follows, sinking deep into its massive head. The creature shudders, momentarily stunned. It recovers but has had enough, and slinks back into the pool, dodging a strike from Whisper's claws.

The second giant ice frog snaps at Doctor Pepe, its powerful jaws gripping him tightly. He grunts in pain, fighting against its hold.

Fighting through the pain of her wounds, Whisper turns to help Doctor Pepe, her claws slashing his assailant and drawing blood. Realizing she can't endure another attack, she makes a calculated retreat, slipping gracefully back to the cave's entrance, trusting that Doctor Pepe can handle the encroaching threat momentarily.

Reinforcements

As Whisper emerges from the cave, Halite quickly gauges the peril, his resolve igniting. With swift strides, he charges inside, his trident a formidable comfort.

He finds Doctor Pepe still struggling against the frog's relentless grip. Halite drives his trident into the creature's side, but its hold does not falter. Observing the struggle, Elara weaves a melody with her harp, instilling Doctor Pepe with courage. "Remember your agility and cunning!" she calls, the sound of her voice and the vibrations of her harp soothing. She then summons the power of the stars, launching a mote of radiant energy with precision. The frog releases a guttural croak, convulsing under the assault before it releases Doctor Pepe and collapses lifelessly into the pool.

Grateful and relieved, Doctor Pepe quickly regains his composure. Meanwhile, Kragor taps into his ancestral power, muscles tensing with readiness. Yet danger lurks in the shadows. Suddenly, a crossbow bolt strikes Doctor Pepe, drawing a pained cry. Another bolt narrowly misses Halite, while a third strikes him, but only bruises his resilient skin.

Halite spots the assailants: a dwarf and two elves across the pool, crossbows poised. Outside, Scarlet rushes to Whisper's aid, healing her with soothing energy. Renewed, Whisper re-enters the cave, her sling delivering a precise blow to one of the elves before she again retreats gracefully.

Inside, Doctor Pepe, undeterred by pain, fires back with his crossbow but misses. Halite steps forward, throwing a javelin that fells the injured elf with precision. Elara, considering but deciding against leaping across the pool, channels more divine energy, striking the second elf squarely. Kragor whispers a curse, dark power seeping from his words, then unleashes tendrils of energy that knock the remaining life out of the elf. The body plunges into the pool's depths.

magician's loom, stars embedded in the fabric in shimmering constellations that dance in tune with the gentle swells of the sea below. The vessel cuts a silent path through the water, its sails billowing like the unfurled wings of a great celestial bird.

Halite stands towering and firm, with broad shoulders reminiscent of his mountain home. In his gentle hand, he lifts Elara, who now wears an ensemble similar to the garb of dryads and nymphs. She spins, her skirts capturing echoes of ancient songs, her voice a melody above the waves captivating all aboard. Her feet barely graze the timbers, yet it seems the deck itself moves to the rhythm of her bewitching performance.

The seasoned crew, hardened by the sea, find themselves enchanted, moving as if under a benevolent spell, their feet tapping and bodies swaying in time with the bard's ethereal dance. Even the ship's wheel turns with newfound joy.

At the helm is Mera, the usually stern navigator, now smiling widely, her eyes twinkling. She joins in, clapping to Elara's tune, her warm voice breaking the night's rhythm with laughter.

"You," Mera announces, "are the liveliest group we've ever shared this deck with!"

Amidst this spellbound camaraderie, sea and sky blur, the ship an island of revelry on endless waters. The adventurers and crew retire well-fed, sleep coming easily… for most.

A flumph fever dream

Scarlet drifts into a fevered dream, where she transforms into a flumph in a surreal Underdark kitchen. Her halfling form dissolves, and her senses morph— colors become emotions, and telepathic whispers surround her.

As a flumph, Scarlet floats through this otherworldly kitchen, propelled by gentle bursts of gas that emit soft notes harmonizing with her thoughts. Her new perspective reveals the flavors of the Underdark: savory spores from glowing mushrooms, earthy cave lichens, and the briny essence of an underground spring.

Scarlet uses her tendrils to sense psychic vibrations from ingredients, uncovering their essence in waves of color and emotion. She crafts dishes with instinctive precision, her mind orchestrating each task like a conductor.

Communicating with ingredients via telepathy, Scarlet coaxes out hidden qualities and balances flavors into a dance on the palate. She infuses each dish with psychic energy, transforming the meal into a nourishing, enlightening experience.

As the fever dream weaves its finale, Scarlet's consciousness begins to ebb back to reality, her experience as a flumph leaving an indelible mark on her aspirations and inspirations. Awakening with a start, she finds herself back in the familiar surroundings, her halfling body reclaimed but her gastronomic spirit forever expanded by the echoes of her uncanny adventure in the Underdark.

Iron Chef

The day dawns dull and gray, with flurries meeting the sea's gentle waves. High above the decks on the Remorhaz, Whisper and Haldor bond against the ship's soft creaks. "I've never known a day without snow," Haldor admits, his fingers tracing the ropes.

"Truly? Not once?" Whisper asks, intrigued.

"Born in it," he replies. "Though fishing runs in my veins. Glassblades pay well, but the peace of fishing is unmatched. Everyone should learn to fish."

Whisper nods, recalling her warm southern seas where the sun dances lazily on the waves. "The water there welcomes you like an old friend," she says.

Haldor listens, enchanted by the idea of warm seas and … swimming! "Sounds wonderful," he

tight."

Whisper nods and springs into action, her tabaxi agility well-suited to the task. The ropes hum under her deft hands as she climbs, earning an appreciative nod from Haldor.

Meanwhile, the rest of the crew— First Mate Ironfist, navigator Mera, chef Ingrid, and various deckhands— move about the deck with practiced ease.

Ingrid leans over the galley's entrance, her voice booming, "Who among you knows their way around a kitchen?"

Scarlet raises a hand with a grin. "Cooking up something warm sounds perfect right now."

Halite joins Scarlet in the kitchen, exchanging pleasantries with Ingrid as they prepare a hearty stew, the aroma rich with spices mingling in the cold air.

The Snowy Plover

Doctor Pepe, Elara, and Kragor set out to fish off the stern, each facing the sea's challenge in their own way. Doctor Pepe excels, deftly handling his rod, while Kragor grumbles over his struggles, recalling the scarcity of such opportunities in Bladegarden.

Elara's net returns empty, sparkling with only water. She muses, "The ocean guards its treasures today." Kragor, undeterred, hauls in his net with effort, a mystery weighing it down. "I've got something… big!" he exclaims, sweat betraying the cold air.

Haldor helps him retrieve the load, revealing an ancient, barnacle-encrusted anchor inscribed with faded letters, ".he ..owy plover." Whisper's eyes light up with recognition. "The Snowy Plover!" she gasps, recalling tales of a privateer's elusive ship. Captain Stonebeard, intrigued, examines it, seeing a storied addition to the Remorhaz.

Meanwhile, Doctor Pepe succeeds in bringing in an abundant catch, his net teeming with fish. The captain, pleased, acknowledges their efforts. "A week's provisions," he claps, satisfied with both Pepe's skill and their stroke of oceanic luck.

The unexpected gourmet chef

Below deck, Chef Ingrid commands the kitchen with precision, a moon-and-rune amulet around her neck softly clinking. She casts an appraising gaze at Halite. "We will teach you to cook," she declares, and he nods with curiosity.

The galley buzzes with warmth and laughter as Ingrid demonstrates her ritualistic cooking methods. "Here, like this," she instructs, guiding Halite through chopping vegetables with tactical precision.

"Start a restaurant when this is over!" Scarlet jokes, sparking a twinkle in Ingrid's eyes. As Halite presents their culinary creation, the table transforms into a feast: roasted fish glistening with oils, spiced vegetables, and golden bread.

A reverent silence follows the first taste. Elara's eyes widen in delight. "By the stars, what sorcery is this?" she exclaims. Kragor, usually stoic, is awed. "This could rival any feast in Bladegarden," he admits. Agreement ripples through the adventurers.

Whisper purrs contentedly while Doctor Pepe grins roguishly. "Ingrid," he proclaims with a fork's flourish, "your cooking is divine ambrosia."

Ingrid, though gruff, smiles slightly, her amulet flickering like a secret torchbearer. "Serviceable, then?" she asks, already knowing the answer.

Scarlet ceremoniously reaches for seconds. "I could believe this meal holds a druid's magic," she chuckles.

The bard performs

After the meal, the night sky sprawls over the ship like a grand tapestry spun from a dark

Frustrated and fearful, the remaining dwarf curses, raising his crossbow in desperation. He takes aim at Elara, embedding a bolt into her thigh. She gasps, momentarily swaying, her focus clouded by the sting.

Retreating further into the cave's depths, the dwarf's footsteps echo and fade, leaving only the rhythmic drip of water and the murmur of unseen currents.

Crossing the pool

Faced with the challenge of pursuing a dwarf across a frigid pool, the party assesses their options. The wooden beam that seems to have been used by the bandits sits tantalizingly across the water.

Scarlet throws the grappling hook she found at Pelc's in an attempt to catch the beam, but misses. As she draws the hook back in for another throw, it snags something underwater. Halite steps in to help, and together they haul up a mass: a dead bandit and a distressed but living frog!

Kragor, sensing danger, hexes the frog and targets it with an eldritch blast. The frog disintegrates under the force of the blast.

Elara, steadying herself, heals her thigh wound with divine magic. Scarlet mirrors her, healing Doctor Pepe with nature's energies.

Their reprieve is brief. The dwarf reappears, firing a bolt that bounces off Halite's armor. "Damn it," Doctor Pepe grumbles, frustration etched into his features. "We need to see!" He hurls his enchanted dagger, and it thuds into the beam, revealing the far shore with its glow.

Driven by urgency, Whisper leaps onto the wall, climbing swiftly and landing silently on the far side, her eyes finding the dwarf hidden in shadows.

With a flick of his wrist, Halite takes a turn throwing the grappling hook, and this time it secures the beam. He pulls it towards him until it rests fully across the pool, then charges confidently across, joining Whisper. Kragor and the rest of the party follow, anticipation fueling each stride.

Scarlet conjures a flame to illuminate their path. Doctor Pepe retrieves his glowing dagger, its light warding off the gloom, as he brings up the rear.

Seeing them approach, the dwarf panics, firing wildly. The bolt clatters harmlessly off stone.

Interrogation in the Depths

In the dim cave light, Whisper, poised and predatory, lunges at the dwarf, her speed a shadowy blur. Yet the dwarf's shield deflects her strike with a resonant thud that shakes the cavern. Halite follows swiftly, his javelin piercing the dwarf with deadly precision, bringing him to his knees.

Elara arrives, agile and commanding, her voice sharp with authority. "Tell us the secrets of this place."

Despite his pain, the dwarf's eyes remain dull and silent. Kragor steps forward, his voice echoing with Elara's urgency. "When a lady speaks, you damn well better listen."

"What family are you with?" Halite's voice booms.

"The Uttolot family," the dwarf finally admits, defiance lacing his words.

Halite's massive frame looms over him. "And what are you doing in this cave?"

The dwarf swallows hard. "We… we feed the frogs," the dwarf confesses. "I work here. For Hulil. Train them to carry us. They used to eat more— whatever Hulil wanted."

Scarlet's eyebrow arches. "More what?" The dwarf squirms. "Bats, small game, even people. Hulil trained them."

Doctor Pepe notices a bucket… on closer examination, it is full of dead bats. "Interesting. These bats could distract the frogs— a tactical edge."

Halite's gaze darkens. "Tell us about Hulil." The dwarf blanches. "She's sick. Sent several of us to town for a clue to the disease— but none returned. She plans to sell Tulgi's loot in Shadycreek Run. Hoping for a cure."

Whisper leans in. "Are there traps here? Tell us what you know."

The dwarf nods toward the sleeping quarters. "A pit, covered by a bedroll."

Halite growls, "You'll live. For now." The dwarf's resigned eyes hint at fear of what's to come. Doctor Pepe binds the dwarf with rope from his pack. Halite stands guard, an imposing sentinel.

The others turn their attention to the grim task of searching their fallen adversaries. Kragor retrieves a crossbow. "Still serviceable," he notes.

Scarlet counts out coins from a waterlogged purse. "Seven gold, ten silver," she reports, the metal catching the dim light with a dull gleam. "Not exactly a king's ransom."

Dungeon crawl

In the cave, the prisoner shuffles under Halite's stern watch, boots scraping the stone floor. They reach a makeshift camp, a fire pit in the center. Whisper conjures a flame with a soft "Lux naturae," illuminating the scene.

Doctor Pepe's keen eyes catch a bedroll lying suspiciously flat. "It's the pit trap of which the dwarf spoke," he warns, pointing to the hidden danger.

Scarlet uncovers an unopened bottle amongst the camp supplies. "Bald Dwarf whiskey," she notes, smirking. "Made by elves."

"Elves making dwarf whiskey? A fine tale," Kragor chuckles.

"Nice. That might fetch as much as 25 gold pieces," Doctor Pepe notes, his rogue's mind already calculating potential value.

The party's attention shifts to two corridors leading away from the campsite. Halite suggests exploring one, with Doctor Pepe following. The corridor gradually widens, opening into a larger cavern. As their eyes adjust to the dim light, they realize they are surrounded by hanging bats.

Suddenly, the bats stir. Their collective movement creates a rustle of wings that fills the cavern with an ominous sound. Halite, startled, begins stabbing wildly with his trident. The weapon misses the bats entirely, instead striking a nearby stalagmite with a sharp crack.

"We need to go!" Doctor Pepe insists.

The two of them retreat, joining the others who are exploring the second corridor. "Bats," Halite explains simply.

Old Croaker

Kragor is the first to notice the expansive underground pool, its dark waters stretching beyond the reach of their light. The cavern seems to breathe with subterranean stillness, broken only by the occasional drip of water from unseen stalactites.

"What's across there?" Kragor demands, turning to the wounded dwarf. "How do we get over?"

The dwarf's eyes dart nervously across the water. "Well," he says, his voice trembling slightly, "Old Croaker ferries people across."

Before anyone can ask who or what Old Croaker is, a massive shape begins to emerge from the murky depths. Even among giant frogs, this creature is truly enormous— easily the size of a small boat, its skin a mottled green and blue, eyes like dark pools of ancient malevolence.

Scarlet steps forward, her movements calm and deliberate. In her hand, she holds one of the dead bats from their earlier discovery. "Easy now," she murmurs, her voice a soothing melody of nature's own language.

With extraordinary skill, Scarlet reaches out with her hand, gently stroking its massive head.

valuable.

During the discussions, Halite eyes a crystal appropriate for arcane focus. He is taken by it, although he is no spellcaster himself, and agrees to pay ten gold for it from his own stash.

Surreptitiously, Doctor Pepe slips aside with Westeroff to identify the properties of a garnet he has been concealing, the exchange of five gold pieces masked beneath the party's ongoing conversation. Whatever he learns, he keeps to himself.

Errands concluded, the six depart to meet their ship and begin their journey to Eiselcross.

The Remorhaz

The docks of Palebank Village are beginning to bustle as the adventurers approach the sleek silhouette of the Remorhaz, its sails furled and ready. The icy wind nips at their cheeks, adding a rosy hue to faces already aglow with anticipation. Elro greets the party, his presence a reassuring anchor amidst the chaos of departure preparations.

"When you arrive," Elro instructs, "find Orvo Mustave in Syrinlya. He knows the lay of the land. Remember, send back the cure once you've secured it— the Buyer can teleport it directly to us."

Kragor nods, his grave expression matching the gravity of their mission. "Snowshoes— are they useful for the ice?" he inquires. Elro chuckles dryly. "In Eiselcross, where lava sometimes flows under a thin veneer of ice, yes, they'll come in handy."

"How big is this Syrinlya? And how long will our trip be?" Scarlet asks. "Oh, I'd say there's about 250 souls there. And the trip is not too long. I expect you'll arrive about four days hence."

Whisper surveys the Remorhaz as the party is brought on board. It is a small ship with three sails, armed with two ballistas, one fore and one aft. "A fast ship meant as a scout and message courier," she thinks to herself.

Aboard, Captain Stonebeard presents a polished performance. His eyes twinkle with exaggerated warmth as Elro steps aboard, each syllable dripping with supplication. "Ah, welcome to the Remorhaz, Master Elro," he croons, offering a low bow as if addressing nobility. The captain's voice is rich as cream, his deferential tone almost theatrical.

Elro acknowledges him with a nod, the hint of a smile touching his lips. "I trust you'll see them safely to Syrinlya, Captain. Their mission is of utmost importance." Stonebeard gestures expansively around the ship, his posture rigidly respectful. "But of course, Master Elro. We are honored to have them."

Even as they talk of weather patterns and navigation routes, Stonebeard's demeanour remains flawless. His subordinates echo his pleasantries with subtle nods and murmurs of agreement. The atmosphere is one of airbrushed civility— concealing the practical grittiness essential to life at sea.

However, the moment the Remorhaz pushes past the harbor's mouth and Palebank diminishes into a mere silhouette against the frosty horizon, a discernible shift occurs, like the release of a drawn bowstring.

Captain Stonebeard's genial façade melts away, replaced by the steely visage of a seasoned mariner. "Alright, enough pandering," he declares brusquely, rolling his shoulders as if shedding a constrictive garment. "This ship won't sail itself, and there's work to be done."

The party exchanges looks of mild surprise, prompting Stonebeard to offer a half-smile. "Don't look so shocked," he rumbles. "Out here, we run a tight ship, which means everybody pitches in."

Whisper, ever the quick study, steps forward. "What can I do? I have… some experience at sea," she says humbly.

Stonebeard appraises her lithely efficient frame. "Help Haldor with the rigging. Keep those sails

Kragor's arcane resonance

The wind howls as Kragor sits alone, tracing patterns in the frosty air. He dwells on the night before— a restless night as if he had nightmares he could not remember. Upon waking he'd found his fingernails cracked and caked with mud, despite recalling his fastidious evening routine. Lost in these thoughts, an arcane potential vibrates in the air unnoticed.

As he absent-mindedly mutters an incantation, the cosmic swirl of his thoughts unlocks a hidden door. An esoteric rite unfolds, and to his astonishment, a warm surge of magic fills him, restoring some of the energy he expended earlier— a tether to a newfound reservoir of power.

Kragor feels further pulses of unfamiliar eldritch energy. Tentatively, he pulls at invisible strands of weave, knitting a protective cocoon around his form. As the surge reaches is zenith, he senses new ferocity in his ability to blast foes with beams of crackling energy. This agonizing blast will now carry his own formidable willpower in every cast, more impactful than ever before.

Empowered, Kragor contemplates this new reality, still alone yet invigorated, clutching these gifts like lifelines against the cold.

Doctor Pepe's subtle mastery

In the dancing shadows, Doctor Pepe reclines near the hearth, his mind whirring through possibilities. As a rogue, his path is a tapestry of subtlety and effectiveness, and tonight, he seeks to enhance these skills further.

Sipping spiced cider, an internal shift sharpens his senses. Every sound— the clink of tankards, the creak of floorboards— crystalizes into focus. He realizes time yields to his will, revealing an ability to exploit the lulls between heartbeats.

Grinning, he tests this newfound quickness, running a stealthy route between tables up to the rooms, completely undetected. Each moment forms with unclouded insight, readying him to weave through shadows, more agile than swirling snow.

As night deepens, each adventurer, transformed by their experiences within the Jolly Dwarf, readies for the unknowns awaiting in Eiselcross. Outside, whispers of snow and secrecy abound, but with increasing potential, each one braces for the stories and trials of tomorrow.

Prepare for departure

The next morning, the adventurers awake well-rested and invigorated. The warmth of the inn lingers like an inviting blanket, fortifying them against the chill that awaits outside. After a hearty breakfast and a few shared laughs, their eyes are set on the tasks ahead.

Their path leads first to Mathias's Stuffs, an establishment with all the disarrayed charm of a barn filled with a collector's treasures. There the party quickly trades with the harried elf proprietor Mathias to procure equipment and provisions for their expedition: a quarterstaff for Whisper, a few javelins for Halite, bolts and arrows for Doctor Pepe and Elara, a unique two-billed olive drab hat for Doctor Pepe, and a month's provisions. They more than offset their purchases by selling the scimitars and crossbows they acquired from the defeated bandits.

Thanks to Kragor's curiosity, they also learn a useful tidbit about Eiselcross from Mathias. The lands are inhabited by "wild folk" who largely keep to themselves, except for one group among them: a violent group whose members have black streaks across their faces.

Anxious to discover as much as they might of the Aeorian artifacts Urgon found, they make their next stop the home of Westeroff, the retired wizard mentioned by Gramini. But, they learn little to help them: Westeroff is not a fan of music; a spellcasting costing them five gold reveals the dagger is magical; and the remaining items are mundane although

To everyone's amazement, the creature seems to relax under her touch, its previous menace transforming into something almost docile. "We need to cross," she tells it softly. Old Croaker, understanding, moves to the pool's edge.

"Well," Elara says, stepping forward with a mixture of excitement and trepidation, "I'll go first." She carefully climbs onto the frog's broad back, her movements careful but confident. Old Croaker begins to swim across the underground pool, Elara perched atop it like an unlikely queen of this subterranean realm.

Tiamat's priestess

Elara clings to Old Croaker's back as they glide across the underground pool. Dismounting with practiced grace, her sharp eyes survey the cavern. An enormous fire illuminates a scene of unsettling drama— shadows dance across stone, cast by two robed figures kneeling before a tapestry depicting a fearsome multi-headed dragon.

The robes of the dwarf woman and the male elf match the tapestry's hues. The dwarf's blued skin betrays the creeping freezing disease.

Pressing against the cavern wall, Elara watches as Old Croaker swims back for her companions: Halite, Doctor Pepe, Kragor, and Scarlet. Whisper stays behind, guarding their captured dwarf informant.

When the party finally joins Elara on the far shore, Scarlet studies the tapestry with a scholar's precision. "Tiamat," she murmurs, more to herself than to her companions. "The scaled tyrant. Embodiment of greed. One of the betrayer gods, sworn enemy of Bahamut, the Platinum Dragon."

"A betrayer god?!," exclaims Elara.

Startled, the robed figures turn. Their fire-cast shadows loom monstrously. The dwarf is undoubtedly Hulil Lutan, Tiamat's priestess.

"Halt!" Hulil barks, her voice crackling with authority. Her diseased skin gleams with those telltale blue streaks. "Who dares approach our sacred space? Drop your weapons and explain yourselves!"

Elara steps forward, her diplomatic mask sliding into place. "We are sent by the dragons," she says smoothly, "to understand the origin of this disease."

Elara's deception falls flat, and Hulil lets out a sharp, mirthless laugh. "Lies! You're nothing but intruders!"

Kragor responds, a sickening glow crackling as he hexes the elf. From his outstretched hand a purple shock of darkness blasts forward but misses and strikes stone harmlessly.

Scarlet charges, swinging her quarterstaff fueled by druidic power, but misses the elf by inches. On the other hand, Doctor Pepe's crossbow bolt finds the elf's neck, silencing him forever.

Halite throws his javelin with horrifying force and it pierces Hulil's hip, pain twisting her features. "Flee!" she commands in response, magical compulsion threading her words. But Halite's will remains unbroken.

A spectral sword materializes, its pommel shaped like a dragon's claw. It swings at Halite, missing him by a hairsbreadth.

Elara's shortbow sings, her arrow finding Hulil's shoulder. The dwarf winces but remains standing.

Kragor now turns his hex on Hulil, firing another eldritch blast that goes wildly off-target.

Doctor Pepe's next shot is solid, sinking deep into Hulil's shoulder and driving her back momentarily.

Hulil's hand summons a sickly green, jagged blade. She swings it at Halite, but his armor deflects the strike. Then, with practiced motion, she pulls out a potion and drinks. Instantly, her wounds begin to heal.

In the dimly lit cavern, Elara's fingers dance

over her shimmering harp. Hulil pauses as the chilling notes paint vivid fears across her mind, yet, fortified by sheer willpower, she resists the full force of the arcane assault.

With a gesture imbued with ancient malevolence, Kragor again unleashes his eldritch blast, a tendril of otherworldly light that tears through the fabric of reality, wrapped in the chill embrace of necrotic energies. This time the blast impacts Hulil, and it seethes with the whispers of forgotten realms, unraveling her very essence beneath a suffocating miasma of decay. The force spreads like a dark plague, methodically consuming vitality and sowing despair in its wake, leaving naught but a hollow echo of cosmic dread.

Allowing no time for Hulil to recover, Scarlet channels natural energy through her quarterstaff, its wood shimmering with an ethereal glow. As the staff connects with Hulil's jaw, Scarlet's druidic power amplifies the force of the strike, delivering a bone-jarring impact that crackles with mystical energy.

Hulil staggers to her feet, fury and agony blazing in her eyes like twin infernos. Doctor Pepe, with ice-cold precision, discharges another bolt, tearing into the dwarf priestess's abdomen.

Nearby, Halite hears a splash behind him but remains steadfast. With a swift motion, he plunges his javelin into Hulil's heart. Her eyes wide, the fire within them slowly extinguishing as she collapses, she rasps a final curse: "May you be consumed by endless desire… let your victories sow only tyranny and ruin… may all… you covet… turn to ash in your grasp."

Beast gonna feast

Meanwhile, hearing the sounds of battle echoing across the cavern, Whisper knocks out the bound dwarf. Determined to join the fray, she attempts to scamper across the cave wall. Instead, she slips and falls with a splash into the water.

Old Croaker startles at the sudden disturbance. The massive frog's head snaps toward Whisper, jaws wide, but miraculously misses. Whisper swims away from the predatory amphibian and begins climbing the wall again.

Old Croaker leaps at Whisper but cannot quite reach her, its massive form creating waves in the underground pool.

Elara attempts to calm the massive frog. "O magnificent amphibian, if you take us back across," she offers, "we'll give you more food." But Old Croaker has other ideas. "Kitten sandwich," the frog seems to communicate, eyeing Whisper with hungry intent.

Kragor hexes the frog and attempts to blast it with eldritch energy. "Damn it!" he curses as the blast goes wide.

Doctor Pepe also shoots wildly into the darkness, his bolt disappearing without effect.

"Who needs enemies with friends like these," Elara sighs.

Whisper manages to scramble away into the main cavern, and drops to the floor. "Fucking frog!" she mutters.

Halite surveys the aftermath of battle, a grim idea forming. With raw, brutal strength, he reaches down to the fallen elf and— with a sickening tear— removes a hand from the corpse. He tosses it to Elara, who catches it with a mixture of horror and fascination.

Old Croaker lurches toward Elara, its massive form seeking a meal. The frog's jaws snap, but miraculously miss her. Elara, her stomach turning, holds out the elf's hand. The massive amphibian sits back, mouth opening like an oversized baby bird expecting a treat.

"Lovely," she mutters. She tosses the hand into the frog's waiting maw. Old Croaker catches it with frightening efficiency, then silently slips back into the pool, leaving nothing but ripples in its wake.

contemplating the challenges to come, and each preparing to rise to meet them in their own way.

Elara's melodies

Elara sits cross-legged, her harp resting in her lap. Her fingers begin a gentle dance across the strings, pulling forth harmonies that weave enchantments into the air. Each note is a thread of light, etching new incantations into her soul. She breathes deeply, and with each exhale, she unlocks a melody for healing, soothing as a lullaby carried on a gentle breeze.

Her focus deepens as the harp sings secrets and tales untold. A profound understanding blossoms within her—an unfolding of expertise perfectly attuned to performance and persuasion. The music whispers of connections, of influence, and suddenly, untapped potentials reveal themselves. She feels an unexpected strength, as though no skill is beyond her grasp.

As the final chord fades like a promise into the air, Elara stands, her heart ready to enchant the world beyond the tavern's doors. Her melody is an invitation to the stories waiting for her.

Whisper's silent growth

In a shadowed corner of the bustling tavern, Whisper meditates, her eyes closed to the revelry around her. The scent of ale and roasting meat drifts past, unnoticed. Deep within her, a soft glow emanates, invisible among the clamor. She envisions her paws moving with blinding speed, imagining a flurry of precise blows. Her mind crafts a dance of agility, untouchable and swift.

Her meditation grows deeper, unlocking secrets of uncanny resilience. An internal wellspring reveals itself, capable of conjuring healing warmth in times of need. The tavern's noise recedes as strength flows through her veins. Whisper opens her eyes, calm and recharged, ready to step into the world beyond with renewed vigor.

Scarlet's communion with nature

Scarlet stands by an open window, the night air alive with the scent of pines. She surrenders to the rhythm of the earth, her pulse syncing with the heartbeat of the soil. Against the swirling snow, an owl materializes from the darkness, its eyes twin moons reflecting wild mysteries. It lands on her shoulder, bringing with it an aura of calm authority.

In that silent exchange, Scarlet absorbs knowledge and guidance from the owl, feeling its ancient wisdom permeate her. She learns to embrace the forms of earthly creatures, realizing that these shapes are not mere disguises but expressions of the natural world's spirit.

Her mind envisions herself as a lithe wolf leaping through snow, a spider weaving webs, a silent rat, a charging boar. With her companion perched beside her, Scarlet feels ready to delve into nature's mysteries, newly emboldened by the owl's presence.

Halite's martial resolve

By the hearth, Halite sits enveloped in the glow of crackling fire. Snowflakes strike the frosted windows, whispering secrets of distant mountains. His mind drifts back to battles past, his tactical acumen sharpened over countless conflicts.

With the heat of the meal and hearth, a shift occurs within him. His warrior spirit thrums louder than the winter winds, power tingling through his veins. He imagines the battlefield where, when stakes are highest, he might unleash two brutal strikes in a heartbeat.

His strategic mind sharpens, foreseeing paths to success even in uncertainty, channeling physical and mental stamina into piercing clarity. Halite rises, his eyes gleaming with the promise of battles yet to come, thankful for the land's icy gifts shaping his destiny.

round of guests even consider laying a foot in here!" His voice quivers with determination as he hurries off toward the back. But before he retreats entirely, he turns back toward the adventurers, his eyes pleading yet grateful. "Make sure Elro knows what you've uncovered. If anyone can coordinate the village through this, it's him. And thank you… truly." He disappears into the back of the inn, leaving the party in the flickering warmth of the common room.

The cause and the cure

The lingering warmth of the Jolly Dwarf fades as the adventurers step into the chill evening air, the glow of lamps casting long shadows across the path. They gird themselves for another trek in the icy wilderness, but the promise of knowledge draws them toward the dwelling of the wizard Westeroff.

Just as they're about to depart, Elro approaches with hurried steps, his breath visible in the cold as he greets them. "Ah, just in time," he says, voice laced with urgency. "I've received word from my contacts. They've confirmed some crucial details about this disease— called the Frigid Woe."

The party gathers closer, attentive. "Frigid Woe?" Elara echoes, eyes wide.

"Yes," Elro affirms, nodding gravely. "It is a weapon that originates from Aeor, and it is familiar to the folks of Eiselcross. But there is hope— a cure exists, stored in golden vials by the Aeorians— a milky white liquid. Wherever Urgon found those vials, that might be our best hope of finding a cure."

Kragor scratches his chin thoughtfully. "And you believe the Aeorians created this… to fight the gods?"

Elro nods. "Precisely. They despised the gods, and Frigid Woe might have been some experimental weapon against them." He reaches into his satchel, producing a small pouch and extending it to them. "This is 100 gold pieces. Your reward for solving the mystery of this sickness."

Before anyone can respond, he inquires, "Have you accounted for all of the powder?"

Doctor Pepe steps forward, quick to respond. "We've managed to gather all we could, from both of the vials that Urgon found."

Elro continues, "I want to hire you to travel to Eiselcross and retrieve this cure. There's a ship, the Remorhaz, that will take you there. Find the cure, use of it what you need, but the rest… At Syrinlya, you'll find an elf, an Uthordurnian, that goes by the moniker 'The Buyer'. Give the cure to him, and he can teleport it back here to Palebank. Do this, and you will be rewarded 200 gold."

Elara, ever the bargain hunter, stirs the conversation. "Considering the journey's danger, perhaps we require a bit more compensation for our troubles…"

Elro gives her an appraising look, recognizing the negotiation for what it is. "I'll tell you what— securing these blue vials is vital. We can't risk any more exposure. I'll give you 200 gold for both of them."

Satisfied with the transaction, Elara turns to less mercantile matters. "What about Irven's family, Elro? They've handled the powder."

Understanding the weight of her concern, Elro promises, "I'll see to it that they're looked after." The sincerity in his eyes reflect his commitment to his people. "But their best chance is for you to find the cure. Join the Remorhaz at the docks tomorrow morning, and godspeed in your search."

Novices become adepts

As night casts its velvet cloak over Palebank Village, the adventurers decide to postpone their errands until the next day. They return to the warmth of the Jolly Dwarf, each

What lies within

The party scans the room. Beyond the bodies and the imposing altar, a single chest sits conspicuously against the cavern wall. The massive Tiamat tapestry looms overhead, its multi-headed dragon seeming to watch their every move.

A quick search of the bodies yields eight gold pieces and five silver pieces, but no keys.

Doctor Pepe approaches the chest, his rogue's eye immediately drawn to its unusual lock. Shaped like a dragon's head, the lock bristles with intrigue. Small pin holes pepper its surface, each filled with a fine blue powder. "Interesting," he mutters, carefully examining the mechanism.

Using a leather pouch to protect his hand, he begins to extract the blue powder. It's abundant, but his practiced fingers manage to contain most of it within the pouch.

Scarlet steps forward to examine the chest. She closes her eyes and murmurs, "Revela nocuit et morbus." As the words weave through the air, a soft luminous aura emanates from her hands, casting an ethereal glow.

"There's magical contagion in the pouch," she warns. "And in the chest itself." She pauses, her gaze shifting. "Oh, and Old Croaker? Definitely venomous."

Working together with Elara, Doctor Pepe carefully picks the lock. The chest opens with a soft click, revealing its treasures: a gilded scroll case, a jade statuette of a storm giant, a quiver with six clearly magical arrows, a silver ring set with a jasper stone, 800–900 coins, and an old notebook.

"These," Doctor Pepe says, "match the items on Urgon's receipt. Except the two blue vials are missing."

Doctor Pepe beckons the others closer. With meticulous care, he removes the chest's contents, ensuring no blue powder is disturbed. He begins to count the coins, his fingers moving methodically. "Let's see," he mutters. "415 copper pieces, 234 silver pieces, 43 electrum pieces, and 112 gold pieces."

Halite takes the notebook, his massive hands carefully turning the pages. His eyes narrow as he reads Hulil's journal. "This is interesting," he says. "Hulil was trying to collect funds to purchase a cure for her disease. She sold one of the blue vials to someone named Irven Liel."

The party exchanges knowing glances, the weight of their discovery hanging in the air like a promise of deeper mysteries yet to be unraveled.

With nothing more to explore, and exhausted from the morning's events, they decide to leave. They coax Old Croaker once more with bat treats, using the massive frog to ferry them back across the underground pool. Retracing their steps, they exit the cavern.

As they step outside, they find the sun high in the sky, its warm light a stark contrast to the damp, dark world they've just left behind.

Whisper looks back at the cave entrance. "Fucking frog," she mutters under her breath.

Frigid Woe

As the sun sets over Palebank Village, casting a warm glow, the adventurers return to Gramini's shop. Seeking answers about the mysterious blue powder, they notice a familiar sight— their own traded t-shirt featuring Scanlan Shorthalt, now framed above a lipstick-stained autographed card, and priced at 500 gold pieces. Unfortunately, Gramini has no insight to offer, but does recommend speaking to Elro and to a retired wizard named Westeroff.

On the way back to the Jolly Dwarf, the party encounters Elro. "Hail, my friends. What news do you bring?" he asks.

Elara explains all that has happened in the cavern: the bandits, the frogs— especially Old Croaker, and Hulil's role as the leader. Elro responds, "That explains the deranged dwarf our Glassblades caught running by town with his hands bound. He's now in jail. I thank you for ridding our village of the scum. There was a bounty on that gang: 75 gold pieces. You've earned it."

Kragor blurts out, "Have you heard the name Irven Liel?"

"No," respods Elro. "Should I have?"

"I don't know. But we found a journal of Hulil's, and it recorded that she sold an Aeorian artifact— a blue vial— to one Irven Liel. We believe this vial is connected to the sickness." Kragor goes on to explain Hulil's condition, the blue powder seen in the chest, and the vials.

"That does seem consequential. I will post a message to Syrinlya about this. It's an outpost of Uthodurn on Eiselcross— perhaps they can make something of your tale." says Elro. "Meanwhile, I suggest you ask about town for this Liel fellow."

The Liel-Tethwicks

Once the party arrives at the Jolly Dwarf, Elara approaches the bar with a knowing smile. "We'd love to get some dinner, Arl," she requests smoothly, sliding six silver pieces across the counter. "Coming right up," Arl replies, flashing a grin as he pockets the coins.

Once seated, Elara's gaze lingers on a nearby family she recognizes from earlier. They seem a motley bunch: two adult men and twin tiefling girls. Curiosity piqued, she leans closer and asks Arl, "Who's the family over there?"

Arl scratches his beard. "Oh, them? That's the Liel-Tethwicks. Irven there is a bookseller, traveling far and wide. On their way to Uthodurn, they are."

Halite perks up at the mention of books. "A bookseller? Fancy myself a reader," he comments, a hint of enthusiasm in his voice.

Irven Liel, overhearing, turns to them with a friendly wave. "Indeed, we are booksellers," he confirms. "Irven Liel, at your service. This is my dearest husband, Fenton Tethwick; and our two lovely daughters, Honor & Magic. We take orders and ship to stores from here to Uthodurn— wholesalers. Even Gramini is planning to stock some of our best sellers."

Recognizing the name "Irven Liel" from Hulil's journal, Whisper, ever the blunt one, asks outright, "How about vials?"

Irven's expression briefly turns guarded. "Uh, who have you been talking to? I don't know about any vials."

"What kind of books do you sell?" Elara asks, trying to avoid spooking the merchant before having the chance to get his whole story.

Irven, his caution momentarily set aside, says "Oh, 'Feather Leather' is flying off the shelf these days." He laughs at his own joke.

Halite gives a good-natured sigh, a touch disappointed that Irven isn't in retail business directly. "Shame you're not a typical bookseller; could have browsed all afternoon."

Elara leans in, her voice lowered and serious. "We're on a quest to solve the popsicle sickness affecting the village. We came across some blue vials, and your name is connected to them."

Irven swallows visibly, his glance darting to one of his daughters before he replies, "The vial… I hope it has nothing to do with the sickness." His voice gains a note of concern.

Halite, sensing a deeper conversation is needed, suggests, "Perhaps we should speak privately." Irven nods, then turns to his husband. "Fenton, could you keep an eye on the girls?" To the tieflings, he says, "Daddy's just going to discuss book business with these fine folk."

Fenton Tethwick nods in understanding and begins talking animatedly with the twins, keeping them distracted.

In a quieter corner of the tavern, Irven reveals a small blue vial from his coat, a hairline crack marring its otherwise perfect surface. "I bought this from a woman named Hulil who needed quick money. Met her on the road," he explains, a touch of defensiveness creeping into his tone. "Is this related to the disease? She claimed it was a magical artifact from Aeor, something that would fetch a high price. I paid 40 gold with the intent of selling it for much more."

Whisper, sensing the urgency of the situation, interjects gently, "Perhaps you'd allow Scarlet to check for the disease?"

Irven nods hesitantly, his anxiety clear. "My whole family has touched this…" he confesses, fear evident in his eyes.

Scarlet focuses, fetching something from her pouch and murmuring an incantation under her breath. A soft glow emanates from her hands as she confirms, "It's the same magical contagion, just like in the chest we found." She gives Irven a serious look. "I think you should spend some quality time with your children," she advises. Irven blanches.

Irven's shoulders slump, his fear for his family's safety evident in his eyes. Taking the fragile vial into his pouch with extreme care, Doctor Pepe remarks, "Best not to touch this further."

Halite adds, "Anyone in the family showing any symptoms? Blue streaks of the skin? Inner chill? Slowed movements?" Irven shakes his head, his relief tempered by worry.

Elara gives him a hopeful smile. "Don't lose hope. You've met the right people. We'll find a cure and return."

Irven does his best to smile, gratitude momentarily overshadowing his anxiety. "Thank you. If nothing else, perhaps I can get you a signed copy of 'Feather Leather' when this is over."

Their conversation concluded, the party returns to their table, now laden with an evening meal of salt fish, squid, and bread. As they eat, Whisper suggests, "Maybe we should talk Arl into a deep clean of the area, just in case."

Halite calls Arl over, his voice bearing the gravity of their findings. "Arl, we suspect that some of the items linked to this accursed disease might have been handled here. A thorough cleaning is advisable to ensure safety."

The dwarf's eyes widen, the jovial air around him dissipating like mist in the morning sun. His hands flutter nervously. "You're saying… here? In my inn? By the gods, what if it's already spread?"

Sensing his rising panic, Elara steps in smoothly, her voice a balm of reassurance. "Arl, take a deep breath. We've caught this early enough, and with some care, we can prevent any further trouble. Trust us, we're on top of this."

Arl nods, though his brow remains furrowed with concern. "Right, right. I'm on it. I'll have the place spick and span before the next